

Boucherie Multiuse Pathway

Colin Madland

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Dear West Kelowna City Council,

Thank you for your work and your service to the community of West Kelowna.

I am a very regular user of the full length (and beyond) of the Boucherie Multiuse Pathway both as a cyclist and a walker of a dog. The current state of the pathway is a significant improvement of safety over the previous active transportation infrastructure along Boucherie Road, meeting one of the key goals of the 2023 project.

However, there are still notable deficiencies in the pathway.

Gravel Sections Limit Access by Road Cyclists

As you know, the current pathway is a patchwork of paved and gravel sections. There is a short paved section beginning at Green Bay Road to the top of the first little hill, terminating at a hairpin turn at the bottom of the Quail's Gate Winery (QG). This is followed by a long, winding gravel section through another long curve, terminating at the first access point to QG. There is then a short paved section alongside the winery, ending at Sunnyside Road, then there is another gravel section that ends at Hatch Winery.

The long gravel section along QG and below Boucherie Road is ideally situated to get cyclists and scooter riders off of the most dangerous section of Boucherie Road, through the S-curves. However, since it is gravel, people who ride road bikes (skinny, high pressure tires), and those riding powered scooters (small tires) tend to avoid this section, preferring to ride along Boucherie Road, putting themselves as well as drivers at risk. So the current configuration and construction does not fully meet the goal of getting non-motorized transportation off Boucherie Road.

Recommendation

- The remaining gravel sections of the Boucherie Multi-use Pathway should be paved.

Gravel Sections are Vulnerable to Vandalism

The gravel surface of the pathway is very regularly vandalized by users riding electric motorcycles. Note that I am not talking about e-bikes which provide pedalling assistance for users, but electric motorcycles that are grossly overpowered for unregulated use on pathways and roads. [I provide video evidence of the damage caused by these motorcycles at this link.](#)

Not only do these motorcycles damage the surface, putting pathway users at risk, but the damage is compounded when it rains as the ruts create drainage routes for the runoff, causing significant erosion. A single pass of a plow in the spring does not fix these problems.

Recommendation

- The gravel sections of the Boucherie Multi-use Pathway should be paved.

Gravel Sections are Not Safe

The long gravel section below QG is dangerous for wheeled users travelling downhill. The pathway is at an -8% grade on gravel going into a sharp 180 degree corner with a wooden fence on the outside of the corner. As there are no warning signs, it would be very easy for someone to come in with too much speed and crash into the fence. This is made worse because this corner is very often vandalized, as described above.

Following that, there is a transition from gravel to pavement in the middle of a hairpin turn, going downhill. There is almost always loose gravel on top of the pavement, making this a tricky corner. Again, this is a very regular spot for vandals to damage the pathway, making it less safe.

Recommendations

- pave the trail!
- since paving will lead to greater speeds along the trail, there needs to be significant signage in the downhill direction warning of upcoming tight corners and oncoming traffic.
- there needs to be traffic calming measures, such as offset gates, installed throughout the S-curves to slow traffic as well as prevent e-motorcycles from abusing the pathway.

Please feel free to contact me at colin@madland.ca if you have any questions.

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